began to fight our way back into the game and took 14 off one over after Virat sent out a message that there was rain around. With a little luck – one six cleared the fielder on the boundary by a few inches – we reached our target with an over and a half to spare. I finished unbeaten on 79 runs from 47 balls, and was happy to have made a difference for the team when we had seemed down and out in a vital match.

The final of IPL 9 was played at the Chinnaswamy Stadium in Bengaluru on Sunday 29 May, and our opponents were Sunrisers Hyderabad, brilliantly captained by David Warner. The Australian opener won the toss, seized the initiative by deciding to bat first, and led from the front as he scored 69 from only 38 balls. We regained some control in the middle of the innings but it was another big-hitting Australian, Ben Cutting, who cut loose in the closing overs.

It was our stadium, our crowd and, we dearly hoped, our big night, but we conceded 52 runs from the last three overs and were left to chase a target of 209 to win the game and take the title.

Virat had asked me to say a few words to the team before the match and I had urged everyone to believe that, whatever happened in the game, whatever challenges we would face, however difficult it got, we would prevail and get there in the end. As we prepared to start our chase, we really did need to keep believing.

Chris Gayle gave us exactly the start we needed, Virat was settling into his rhythm again, and we seemed on track at 112 without loss at the end of the tenth over. Then Chris was caught at third man for 76 in the 11th over, Virat was unfortunate to play on in the 13th over and I skied a drive and was caught at deep mid-off in the 14th over.

We fought hard to stay in the game, to a point where we needed 18 runs off the last over, but the Sunrisers bowlers had proved themselves to be the most effective attack in the competition, and they held their nerve and deservedly closed out a victory by eight runs.

Our dressing room was very quiet afterwards. We had come back from